

CHAPTER 19 — Don't Look at the Threat

Elias returned before sunrise wheeling an old bicycle through the rear yard, mud up one trouser leg and the chain hanging loose.

Zoe was already awake.

She sat at the farmhouse kitchen table with the supply list beside her and the backpack beneath the chair. The range had gone out during the night. Pale light entered through the window above the sink and gave the room the colour of cold milk.

"Where were you?" she asked.

Elias closed the back door and checked the latch twice.

"Preparing the return route."

"You left without telling me."

"You were asleep."

"That isn't an answer."

"No."

He removed his coat. Rain had darkened the shoulders.

Zoe looked towards the yard.

"You said we were going into town together."

"We are."

"You also said you wouldn't move me while I was asleep."

"I didn't."

"You moved yourself."

"That was not part of the agreement."

"It should have been."

Elias hung the coat beside the range.

He was quiet for a moment.

"I drove the farm van to the livestock market," he said. "It is parked inside a stall at the far end of town. The booking sits under the van's old agricultural account, not this address. I came back on the bicycle."

"Why?"

"Because we may not return in the same car."

"May not?"

"We assume the estate is clean. We do not assume it stays clean once we use it in public."

Zoe looked towards the bicycle outside.

"Where is that going?"

"Machinery shed."

"So you rode all the way back."

"Mostly."

"What happened to the rest?"

"The chain came off."

She examined the mud along one trouser leg.

"You fell."

"I dismounted badly."

"You fell."

"Breakfast first."

He opened the bread bin.

Zoe folded the supply list and placed it beneath her mug.

"You should have told me."

"Yes."

The admission arrived without defence.

She had been ready to argue against a reason. Agreement left her with the original fact instead.

"Next time, leave a note," she said.

"Next time, I wake you."

"That is worse."

"Then a note."

He cut two pieces of bread.

The correction was small. That was why it mattered.

"Third lesson," Elias said twenty minutes later.

Zoe looked at the piece of toast in her hand.

"You're counting the map exercise."

"I am."

"That was beans."

"It was still a lesson."

"It was geography with legumes."

"Most education improves with food."

She ate the corner of the toast.

"What's the lesson?"

Elias placed two mugs on the table and sat opposite her.

"Don't look at the threat."

"That sounds irresponsible."

"It is, if you stop listening before the explanation."

"I was considering it."

He unfolded yesterday's newspaper and placed it between them.

A photograph on the front page showed a politician pointing towards something outside the frame. Every face behind him looked in the same direction.

"What do you see?" Elias asked.

"A man who likes being photographed."

"What else?"

"People pretending they can hear him."

"Look at the edges."

Zoe studied the image.

A security officer stood behind the crowd. He was not looking at the politician. His attention rested on a gap between two barriers.

"A man watching the exit."

"Why?"

"Because everyone else is watching the person speaking."

Elias tapped the newspaper once.

"The obvious thing occupies attention. The useful thing is often the change around it."

"Like a distraction."

"Sometimes. But surveillance is rarely somebody hiding behind a newspaper with eyeholes cut in it. Most of the time, every individual action is ordinary. A

person buys coffee. Another crosses the road. A car stops for thirty seconds. None of that means anything alone."

"But together it does."

"Sometimes."

"You keep saying sometimes."

"Because certainty is expensive."

Zoe looked again at the photograph.

"So I don't look at the person following us."

"You can look once. After that, watch what moves when they move."

"Who changes direction?"

"Yes."

"Who stops when they stop."

"Yes."

"Who appears after they disappear."

Elias leaned back.

"That is the lesson."

Zoe folded the newspaper.

"What if I see something?"

"You tell me without turning towards it."

"How?"

"Say something that belongs in the conversation."

"Such as?"

He looked at the list.

"Tell me we forgot the soap."

"We do need soap."

"Then choose something else."

"The flowers are wrong."

Elias glanced at her.

"Why flowers?"

"I don't know. It sounds normal."

"It does not sound normal."

"It will in a town with flowers."

He considered this and nodded.

"The flowers are wrong."

"And then?"

"Then I believe you heard the lesson."

"Not that I'm right."

"No."

Zoe looked at him over the edge of the newspaper.

There it was again: the difference between being trusted and being indulged.

She preferred the first even when it came with less comfort.

They left the farmhouse at nine fifteen.

The estate car had been swept before breakfast. Wheel arches. Lights. Wiring. Seats. Boot lining. Underside.

Zoe held the torch for half of it and checked the places Elias had shown her.

Nothing had been added.

They took only what they could abandon.

The backpack remained with Zoe. Elias carried a canvas shopping bag folded inside his coat. Cash was divided between three pockets. The list contained food, batteries, soap, basic painkillers, socks, thread, a second torch and the items Zoe had named the previous evening.

Elias had rewritten the final item in his own handwriting.

He had not hidden it beneath a vague word or moved it to another page.

Zoe noticed.

She said nothing.

The farmhouse disappeared behind the poplars. Elias drove south first, away from the market town, then crossed through two villages before turning north on a road that entered town from the opposite side.

"Why not the direct road?" Zoe asked.

"The direct road answers a question nobody has asked yet."

"What question?"

"Where did we come from?"

She watched the hedges pass.

"So every journey starts with a lie."

"Not a lie. An incomplete answer."

"That is what adults call lies when they need them to sound useful."

Elias glanced at her.

"You are going to be exhausting when you become a lawyer."

"I'm not becoming a lawyer."

"What are you becoming?"

The question was casual.

It still reached somewhere she had not expected.

A week earlier, answers had existed. School. Exams. Jackie sending messages during homework. A future built from choices small enough to argue about.

Now every answer seemed to require knowing which name belonged to her.

"I don't know," Zoe said.

Elias returned his attention to the road.

“That’s allowed.”

No encouragement. No speech about potential. No attempt to invent a future for her.

The permission remained in the car after the subject changed.

The town occupied both sides of a shallow river.

Its centre had been built before cars and resented them accordingly. Delivery vans blocked narrow streets. Buses swung across both lanes to clear corners. Shopkeepers carried crates between parked vehicles while drivers waited with the expression of people personally wronged by architecture.

Tuesday was market day.

Canvas awnings covered the square. Fruit sellers called prices above the bells of the church clock. A fish van had opened one side onto crushed ice and handwritten signs. Two men argued beside a stall selling tools while the vendor continued arranging spanners as if the argument had been included in his rent.

Elias parked on the third level of a concrete car park behind the library.

Not close to the stairs.

Not close to the lift.

Zoe looked through the rear window before opening her door.

A woman strapped a toddler into a car seat. An elderly couple searched separate pockets for the ticket they had apparently given each other. A young man in overalls carried a cardboard tray of drinks towards the far corner.

Nothing repeated.

Elias locked the car.

“Where first?” he asked.

“Chemist.”

“You chose that because it is nearest.”

"I chose it because we need basic painkillers and the other things."

He did not make her specify them again.

They descended by the ramp rather than the stairwell.

The high street had a local rhythm.

People did not simply move through it. They paused in recognised places.

Outside the butcher's, three men in work jackets occupied the same section of pavement while pretending not to block the entrance. At the newsagent, customers held the door for the person behind them even when that person was several steps away. The café filled after ten, emptied when the first bus arrived, then filled again with people who had apparently been waiting for the bus to leave.

Zoe noticed these things because Elias had told her not to search for danger.

Searching for danger made every stranger suspicious.

Looking for rhythm made interruption visible.

At the chemist, Elias remained near the front shelves while Zoe took a basket towards the back.

"You're not following me," she said.

"No."

"You usually do."

"You asked for those items yourself."

"What if someone is in here?"

"Then you leave the basket and walk to the counter."

"And you?"

"I am six metres away."

She looked down the aisle.

He was.

Not close enough to inspect what she bought. Close enough to respond if the room changed.

Zoe selected what she needed, added soap and a packet of ordinary non-prescription painkillers, then stood for too long before a shelf of shampoo.

At home, she had used whatever Helen bought.

At Cain's house, bottles had no labels.

At the cottage, Elias had found a bar of soap hard enough to qualify as masonry.

The choice should have been ordinary.

That made it difficult.

A group of three girls entered the aisle behind her wearing navy school jumpers and carrying identical canvas bags. One complained that her mother had bought the wrong conditioner. Another said it did not matter because she planned to cut her hair herself. The third examined a packet of hair dye and announced that school rules were a form of psychological warfare.

Zoe stood with one hand on a bottle and listened.

One girl noticed her.

"Is that one any good?"

Zoe looked at the bottle.

She had chosen it because the label was green.

"I don't know."

"My sister says it smells like furniture polish."

The other girls laughed.

Not at Zoe. At the description.

The first girl took the bottle from the shelf, opened the cap and smelled

it.

“She’s right.”

She returned it.

“Try that one,” she said, pointing. “It’s cheaper anyway.”

Then the three of them moved towards the cosmetics aisle, still arguing about hair dye.

Zoe picked up the cheaper bottle.

For several seconds, the chemist contained nothing except shelves, fluorescent lights and a decision about shampoo.

She placed it in the basket.

At the till, Elias paid cash without looking at the receipt.

Outside, he handed her the bag.

“You changed brands.”

“You don’t know what brand I was getting.”

“You held the first one for three minutes.”

“It smelled like furniture polish.”

He accepted this as sufficient.

They bought batteries from a hardware shop where every drawer behind the counter had a handwritten label.

The owner tested the second torch before accepting payment.

They bought thread, needles and two pairs of socks from a stall in the covered market. Zoe chose one black pair and one with yellow stripes.

Elias looked at them.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You looked.”

"I was surprised."

"By socks."

"By yellow."

"You own a jacket that smells like a garage."

"That jacket is practical."

"So are socks."

She added the yellow pair.

They bought apples, onions, carrots, bread, tins and fresh milk. Elias reached for cheese. Zoe moved his hand towards hummus without touching it.

"You are becoming controlling," he said.

"You ate it."

"Under protest."

"You ate most of it."

"Evidence obtained under poor conditions."

At a stationery shop, Zoe stopped before a display of notebooks.

The covers showed animals, flowers, slogans and patterns designed by adults attempting to remember what young people liked.

She selected a plain dark-blue one.

"For lessons?" Elias asked.

"No."

He did not ask what it was for.

She added two pencils and a sharpener.

The purchase went into her backpack, separate from the folder and hard drive.

Something ordinary placed beside the evidence.

They reached the square at eleven twelve.

The church clock struck the quarter-hour early.

Elias heard the bell and looked up.

Zoe did not.

She was watching a flower stall reflected in the dark window of a closed travel agency.

A man stood with his back partly towards them while the florist wrapped a bunch of pale lilies in brown paper. He was broad through the shoulders, wearing an ordinary raincoat and dark trainers marked with dried mud.

Nothing about him was wrong.

He had selected flowers.

He had paid.

He accepted change.

Then the florist asked him something.

The man did not answer immediately because his attention had moved to the reflection of the square in the metal side of the fish van.

He recovered, smiled and said something Zoe could not hear.

The florist laughed.

The man took the flowers and walked away without looking at them once.

Zoe continued past the travel-agency window.

A woman sat outside the café with a cup and an open paperback. Her chair faced the river rather than the square. A shopping bag rested beside her feet. A pale repaired scrape marked the outside of her left heel. She turned one page as the flower buyer entered the covered market.

The timing could have meant nothing.

Zoe looked at the café window instead of the woman.

In the reflection, the woman's eyes remained on the book.

A bus arrived beside the square.

For eight seconds its large blue body blocked the view between the café and the covered market.

The woman closed her book.

At the same moment, the man with the flowers emerged from the market through the opposite entrance.

The woman closed her book, stood and went inside, leaving the untouched cup on the table.

The man continued towards the newsagent.

The bus moved away.

Zoe saw a black compact saloon pull from a loading bay it had no reason to occupy and take the bus's place along the kerb.

Different people.

Different actions.

One continuous view.

"The flowers are wrong," she said.

Elias did not alter his pace.

"How wrong?"

"He bought lilies without looking at them. The woman at the café closed her book when the bus blocked them from each other. Then he came out of the other side of the market and a car moved into the bus's place."

"Could be coincidence."

"Yes."

"What else?"

"The woman's coffee was full when she carried it inside."

"Could dislike it."

"She turned one page in nine minutes."

"You timed her?"

"The church bell was early."

Elias carried the shopping bag as though its weight required all his attention. "Where is the man now?"

"Newsagent window. He can see us in the glass."

"The woman?"

"Inside the café or through the rear exit."

"The car?"

"Kerb. Driver wearing a cap. I haven't seen the face."

Elias stopped at a stall selling jars of honey. He lifted one, read the label and put it back. In the curved side of a polished urn, he found the man at the newsagent. Not standing still. Buying a lottery ticket. The flowers rested beneath one arm. The woman did not appear in the reflection. That concerned him more. "Do you recognise the man?" Zoe asked.

"Possibly the driver from the cottage road."

"You didn't see him."

"You described him."

"You believed me."

"Yes."

The answer was quiet enough to belong to the market noise. Elias selected a jar of honey they did not need and paid for it. "What now?" Zoe asked.

"We finish the list."

"You said the return route was prepared."

"It is."

"So we leave."

"Leaving immediately tells them exactly when they were detected."

"They may already know."

"Then we do not make them certain."

Zoe looked towards the hardware shop.

"We already have everything."

"Not the radio batteries."

"They were on the list?"

"They are now."

"You invent supplies when nervous."

"I invent supplies when followed."

"That is worse."

They entered the newsagent.

Reyes saw them through the reflection of the lottery display.

The girl did not look at him.

That was the first indication.

At the cottage track, she had watched through a shutter gap. At the newsagent, she read the lowest row of postcards with concentration too exact for the subject.

Elias selected batteries from a rack near the counter.

The girl stood beside a rotating display and touched none of it.

Reyes placed the lilies on the floor while the cashier printed his ticket.

The flowers had cost more than the coffee.

Vale would mention that later.

She mentioned every unnecessary expense except the ones she caused.

His operational phone vibrated once in his pocket.

A silent signal.

Voss.

Reyes did not reach for it.

Across the road, the black compact saloon remained beside the kerb. Voss sat behind the wheel wearing a cap pulled low enough to alter the visible shape of his face.

Vale had entered through the café and reappeared through the rear service lane after speaking briefly to staff.

She would now be ahead of the subjects.

Reyes accepted the lottery ticket.

“Good luck,” the cashier said.

“I prefer planning.”

The cashier looked at him.

Reyes picked up the flowers.

“Joke.”

It had not sounded like one.

He stepped outside.

Elias and Zoe were still in the shop.

Reyes crossed towards the butcher’s and entered the line behind two local men discussing fencing posts. He did not look back.

The phone vibrated again.

Two pulses.

Possible detection.

He shifted the lilies to his other arm.

Across the road, Voss drove away from the kerb.

The empty space filled almost immediately with a delivery van.

The pattern continued.

Inside the newsagent, Zoe saw the estate car leave in the convex security mirror above the till.

"The car moved."

Elias compared two brands of batteries.

"Direction?"

"Over the bridge."

"Man?"

"Outside. Butcher's queue."

"Woman?"

"I don't know."

"That is the problem."

"You think she is ahead."

"I would be."

The shop door opened.

A mother entered with a pushchair and held the door while her son struggled inside carrying a football too large for the narrow entrance.

Elias paid.

They left behind the family.

For the next twelve minutes, nothing happened.

No repeated face.

No car moving at their speed.

No person crossing twice.

Zoe began to doubt herself.

That was part of the method too.

A poor tail reassured you by becoming visible.

A good one allowed doubt to perform the work.

They passed the café.

The woman's cup remained on the table, full except for one mark of lipstick.

Her book was gone.

At the next corner, a charity-shop window reflected a woman in a dark coat examining postcards outside the tourist office.

Different shopping bag.

Same shoes.

Zoe did not know how she knew they were the same shoes at first.

Then she saw the repaired scuff on the left heel.

The woman chose a postcard of the church, turned it over and smiled at something printed on the back.

She had changed her position.

Not her purpose.

"The coffee was wrong too," Zoe said.

Elias looked at a passing delivery cyclist.

"Where?"

"Behind us. Tourist office. Different bag."

"Same woman?"

"Left heel repaired. Same book in the new bag."

Elias did not ask how she had seen it.

“Good.”

The word was not praise.

It was confirmation that the next part had begun.

They returned to the car park at eleven forty-eight.

Elias used the lift this time.

Inside were four other people: a woman with shopping bags, two workmen carrying a toolbox and a teenage boy eating chips from paper.

Zoe watched the mirrored wall.

The dark-coated woman did not enter.

The doors closed.

“Did we lose her?” Zoe asked.

“No.”

“How do you know?”

“She wanted us to use the lift.”

“Why?”

“One exit. Cameras. Predictable floor.”

The workmen continued talking about a broken boiler.

The teenage boy offered a chip to nobody in particular.

Elias and Zoe exited on level two instead of level three.

They walked up the vehicle ramp.

“Is this allowed?” Zoe asked.

“No.”

“Good.”

At the top, the estate car remained untouched.

A white tradesman's van idled three rows away. The driver appeared to be completing paperwork on a clipboard.

Zoe looked once. No recognition. Elias loaded the shopping into the boot. He handed Zoe the honey. "Keep it in the front."

"Why?"

"It will break beneath the tins."

"We bought it because we were followed."

"It is still honey."

They entered the car. Elias started the engine and drove down through the levels without hurrying. At the exit barrier, the machine rejected the ticket. He tried again. Behind them, a car approached and stopped two vehicle lengths back. Not close enough to pressure. Zoe saw only headlights in the mirror. The ticket failed a second time. A car-park attendant left the office and walked towards them. Elias lowered the window. The attendant examined the ticket, then the barrier machine. "You've folded it."

"It was in my pocket."

"Can't read the stripe when it's folded."

"I have discovered that."

The attendant used a key and raised the barrier manually. The delay lasted one minute and forty seconds. The car behind remained still. No horn. No driver leaning from the window. No ordinary impatience. Zoe kept her eyes on the attendant's reflection in Elias's side mirror.

When they cleared the barrier, the car behind followed.

"Grey hatchback," she said. "One person. Can't see who."

Elias turned left.

The direct road to the farmhouse lay right.

The first circuit took them around the river and back across the same bridge.

The grey hatchback did not follow.

A red van appeared three junctions later and remained behind them through two turns before entering a petrol station.

The black compact saloon from the square passed in the opposite direction five minutes after that.

It did not turn.

Zoe watched the wing mirror.

"Are they following us?"

"Yes."

"I can't see them."

"That is why they use more than one vehicle."

"How many?"

"At least two. Possibly three."

"You said certainty was expensive."

"It is."

"You sound certain."

"I am paying for it in fuel."

They drove towards the industrial edge of town.

Elias took a road signed for the bypass, then left it at the final roundabout and entered a retail park. He parked near a home-improvement warehouse beneath a camera and carried the shopping inside.

Zoe followed.

They spent seven minutes comparing door hinges.

"You don't need hinges," she said.

"I may."

“For what?”

“I will know when I own them.”

He bought none.

They left through the garden-centre exit and returned to the car.

The grey hatchback sat near a fast-food restaurant with no one visible inside.

A man in a dark raincoat stood at an outdoor cash machine.

No flowers.

Zoe recognised the width of his shoulders before the face.

“He changed cars.”

“He may have.”

“The flower man is at the cash machine.”

Elias placed the bread in the boot.

“Don’t look at him.”

“I’m not.”

“What changed around him?”

Zoe scanned the reflections in the warehouse windows.

A woman pushing a trolley stopped to answer her phone.

A taxi collected two passengers.

A white hatchback reversed badly.

At the far end, the dark-coated woman entered a homeware shop and did not collect a trolley.

“The woman is covering the other exit.”

“Good.”

“You said ‘good’ again.”

"This is not the time."

"That means I win later."

"We survive first."

They got back into the estate.

Voss watched from the bypass.

The subjects' route appeared on the operational phone through updates from Reyes and Vale rather than a tracker.

Market square.

Library car park.

River bridge.

Retail park.

No direct movement towards a refuge.

No panic.

No attempt to confront.

"Detection confirmed," Vale said through the earpiece.

Her voice contained no frustration.

Only revision.

"How?" Voss asked.

"The girl probably identified the rotation."

"Not Elias?"

"He reacted after her signal. She appears to have found it."

Reyes joined the channel.

"They are leaving the retail park westbound."

"Maintain distance," Voss said.

"I know."

"Then do it."

A pause.

Reyes's breathing altered.

Not anger exactly.

Resistance to being reminded.

Voss marked the direction on the paper map beside him.

"If they are using a detection route, they will choose somewhere with multiple exits."

"Hospital," Vale said. "Rail station is too exposed and the roadworks limit departure."

"Or livestock market," Reyes said. "Tuesday market. Two vehicle gates, pedestrian path to the bus station."

Voss looked at the town map.

"Livestock market is one possibility. It is closing."

"Which means movement," Vale said. "Vans, traders, gates open."

Voss folded the map.

"Do not close distance. We want the next vehicle, not the confrontation."

Reyes disconnected without acknowledging.

Vale remained on the line.

"He heard you," she said.

"That has never been the same as agreement."

Elias drove west for twenty minutes.

He did not use the bypass.

The route passed a school, a housing estate and a row of garages

before entering open farmland.

The grey hatchback appeared once at a roundabout three cars behind them.

Then it vanished.

A motorcycle took its place for two miles and overtook without looking towards them.

At the next village, Elias turned into a lane marked

No Through Road

.

Zoe looked at him.

"Is it actually a dead end?"

"Yes."

"That seems bad."

"It is useful."

The lane ended at a reservoir car park.

Three vehicles stood near the water. Two fishermen occupied the far bank. A woman walked a spaniel beside the fence.

Elias parked but did not switch off the engine.

No car entered behind them.

They waited four minutes.

Then six.

"Did we lose them?" Zoe asked.

"No."

"You keep saying that."

"They know the lane is a dead end. Following us in would expose whoever does it. They will wait at the junction or cover the roads out."

“So why come here?”

“To confirm they are patient.”

“That is not comforting.”

“It was not intended to be.”

He reversed, left the reservoir and returned towards the village.

At the main road, no vehicle moved immediately.

Thirty seconds later, the red van emerged from a farm entrance behind them.

Zoe saw it.

“They waited.”

“Yes.”

“What now?”

“Now we stop using the car they know.”

The livestock market occupied a wide yard behind corrugated sheds and steel pens.

By two o’clock, most animals and traders had gone. Vans queued at the wash station. Men in waterproof aprons hosed mud and straw towards drains. The café was stacking chairs onto tables.

Elias entered through the east gate.

The red van remained two vehicles behind until a cattle lorry blocked the lane.

Elias turned between two sheds, crossed an unloading yard and parked the estate beneath the upper floor of the auction building.

He removed the shopping.

Zoe kept the backpack.

“Where is the farm van?” she asked.

“Other side of the site.”

"They know we came in."

"Yes."

"They will cover both gates."

"Yes."

"Then how does this work?"

"We don't use either gate yet."

He led her through the auction building.

The public entrance had closed, but the corridor to the café remained open while staff cleaned. Elias bought two teas from a woman who had already switched off half the lights.

"You're the last," she told them.

"We have that effect."

They sat beside a window overlooking the pens.

Zoe did not drink.

The tea looked strong enough to dissolve the cup.

Outside, traders finished loading. Vehicles left in irregular bursts. The red van passed the west gate and continued.

The dark-coated woman appeared beside the office speaking to a man in a high-visibility jacket.

She was smiling.

She had changed the shopping bag again.

"The woman is here."

Elias stirred his tea.

"Where?"

"Office. She's asking something."

"What is the man doing?"

"Pointing towards this building."

"She knows we came inside."

"Yes."

"What is she not looking at?"

Zoe watched the yard.

The farm van waited inside a locked stall across from the wash station. White body. Faded lettering from a feed supplier that no longer existed. Its paperwork remained under the same old agricultural account as the stall booking, with no visible link to the farmhouse address.

Vale did not look towards it.

Neither did the man at the office.

A cattle lorry reversed between them, blocking the view.

Behind it, two workers opened the wash-station barrier to clear a line of departing vehicles.

The ordinary movement created a corridor.

"The west service gate," Zoe said. "Nobody is covering it."

"They don't know it opens."

"You did."

"I checked this morning."

"The woman is watching the public exits."

"Yes."

"And the flower man?"

"Probably watching the estate."

"So we leave the estate."

"Yes."

The lesson completed itself.

Do not look at the threat.

Look at the space the threat believes does not matter.

They left their tea untouched.

The lower corridor smelled of disinfectant, wet straw and fried onions from the closed café.

Elias carried the shopping. Zoe walked beside him rather than behind.

At the corner before the wash station, he stopped.

A worker pushed a wheeled pressure washer across their route.

“Can’t come through here,” the man said.

“Van in Stall Twelve.”

“Market’s closed.”

“I’m collecting it.”

The worker looked at the keys in Elias’s hand, then at Zoe.

“Quickly. We lock the service gate in ten.”

“Understood.”

No invented authority.

No threat.

A key and an ordinary explanation.

They crossed behind the cattle lorry.

The farm van opened on the second attempt.

Inside smelled of dust, feed and cold metal. Two crates had been secured behind the seats to hold shopping.

Zoe climbed in.

Elias placed the canvas bag between the crates and closed the rear

doors.

"Did they see us?" she asked when he started the engine.

"Someone usually sees."

"That isn't the question."

"No one reacted."

She accepted the corrected answer.

They joined the line at the wash station.

The van ahead had sheep markings painted along one side. The driver argued with the attendant about the charge. Behind them, a livestock trailer blocked the mirrors.

Elias kept both hands visible on the wheel.

The service gate opened.

They drove out among six other white vans and turned south.

The estate car remained beneath the auction building.

Reyes watched its only obvious exit.

Vale watched the pedestrian route to the bus station.

Voss covered the western road.

The farm van took a drainage lane between fields and disappeared behind a line of poplars.

They did not drive towards the farmhouse.

For another hour, Elias used roads that crossed rather than approached it.

They stopped beneath a railway bridge and watched the road behind them.

No repeated vehicle.

They passed through a village, circled a small industrial estate and left by a different entrance.

No grey hatchback.

No red van.

No motorcycle.

At a lay-by overlooking flooded fields, Elias switched off the engine.

Rain ticked against the windscreen.

Zoe held the jar of honey between both hands.

"Are we clear?"

"I think so."

"You said certainty was expensive."

"We have spent enough."

"That means no."

"It means we will check twice more before returning."

She placed the honey in the door pocket.

"The woman nearly found the van."

"She found the market."

"She was watching the wrong gates."

"Yes."

"Because she thought the car mattered."

"Because we taught them it mattered."

Zoe looked through the rain.

"They know what we look like now."

"They already had photographs."

"That isn't the same as seeing us."

"No."

"They know we spotted them."

"Yes."

"Do they know it was me?"

"They may suspect."

The answer carried a consequence she had not fully considered.

Until town, Zoe had been part of the burden Elias moved.

Now the hunters might understand that she was part of the mechanism moving back.

"If they do, that makes me more dangerous to them," she said.

"Yes."

"And more valuable."

Elias did not answer immediately.

The rain strengthened.

"It changes how they will treat you," he said.

"That means yes."

"Yes."

Zoe watched the water gather at the bottom of the windscreen.

"You could tell me to stop."

"I could."

"You won't."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because not seeing them would not make them stop seeing you."

She turned towards him.

That was not the whole answer.

He knew she knew it.

"I trust what you notice," Elias said.

The sentence was plain.

No ceremony around it.

Zoe looked away first.

"Your tea at the market was disgusting," she said.

"Yes."

"You still drank some."

"I have survived worse."

"That is not a recommendation."

"No."

The subject changed.

The sentence did not.

At three thirty, Reyes entered the auction building.

The estate car remained where Elias had left it.

Shopping receipts lay inside the centre console. Nothing else.

No maps.

No address.

No tracker.

The boot was empty except for a length of wire used to repair the passenger window.

Reyes closed the boot harder than necessary.

Vale approached from the bus-station path.

“They did not come through the pedestrian exit.”

“I can see that.”

“Can you?”

He looked at her.

Vale examined the wet tyre marks beneath the building.

“Service gate.”

“It was marked staff only.”

“So was the kitchen yard at the café.”

“That is different.”

“It is a door people assume does not count.”

Reyes looked across the pens.

The wash station had closed. Water continued running towards the drains.

Voss arrived five minutes later.

He did not inspect the estate first.

He inspected the market site plan attached to the office wall.

Three public entrances.

One pedestrian path.

One service gate partially hidden beneath a label for drainage access.

He photographed the plan.

“The girl probably saw the rotation,” Vale said.

Voss looked at the abandoned car.

“How sure?”

“Elias changed from ordinary shopping to a detection route only after she signalled. She tracked my position after I changed bag and

location, and she appears to have noticed the vehicle handoffs."

Reyes walked away from the estate.

"She got lucky."

Vale did not follow him with her eyes.

"She identified the same scuff on my heel after I changed the bag and position."

Reyes stopped.

"You wore the same shoes."

"Yes."

"That was careless."

"It was the only repeated detail she could have used."

"You don't know that."

"No," Vale said. "That is the point."

Voss studied the service road.

"They prepared the second vehicle before entering town."

"Probably this morning," Vale said.

"Which means the supply trip was necessary, but exposure was anticipated."

Reyes returned.

"So we know they need supplies and hide nearby."

"We knew that before today," Voss said.

"We know the girl is trained."

"No," Vale replied. "She is learning."

Reyes's expression hardened.

"That should make her easier."

"It makes her less predictable."

Voss folded the site plan along its existing crease.

"We do not repeat the town search."

"Why?" Reyes asked.

"Because they will expect us to search outward from here. The farm van may travel twenty miles before turning back, or a hundred. The estate is meant to occupy us."

"So what do you suggest?"

"We return to the identities."

Reyes looked towards the service gate.

"Paper again."

"Paper found the cottage."

"And then he killed the trail."

"He redirected it," Voss said. "There is a difference."

Reyes kicked a small stone into the drain.

"We had them."

Vale closed her document case.

"No. We saw them."

"That is close enough."

"For you," she said.

Reyes smiled, but nothing in his face became amused.

"One day you are going to analyse a door until the person behind it walks away."

"One day," Vale said, "you are going to open one before we finish checking what is behind it."

Voss looked between them.

Neither spoke again.

They reached the farmhouse after dark.

Elias approached from the west, passed the entrance once and returned twenty minutes later by the northern road. He stopped behind the machinery shed and swept the van before opening the yard gate.

Zoe held the torch.

No device.

No disturbed trim.

No unfamiliar wire.

Inside, they unpacked the supplies onto the kitchen table.

Soap beside the sink.

Batteries in the pantry.

Non-prescription painkillers above the range.

Food divided between what would keep and what needed eating.

Zoe carried her personal items upstairs.

When she returned, Elias had placed the yellow-striped socks beside her notebook without comment.

She picked them up.

"You laughed at these."

"I looked."

"You were surprised."

"That was before they survived surveillance."

"They were in a bag."

"Still counts."

Zoe placed the socks on the back of a chair.

Elias checked the clock.

"Third lesson complete."

" 'You identified the pattern on your third lesson,' " Zoe said, imitating his voice badly.

"I do not sound like that."

"You do when you are trying not to praise me."

"I was going to say exactly that."

"That is praise with paperwork."

He opened the jar of honey.

"We bought this under pressure. We should test whether it was worth the risk."

"You bought it because you panicked at a stall."

"I made a tactical purchase."

"You bought expensive honey."

Elias spread it on bread.

Zoe watched him take the first bite. "Well?" He considered the question with unnecessary seriousness. "Average." She laughed. It escaped before she could stop it. Not loud. Not long. Real enough to alter the room. Elias cut another piece of bread and handed it to her. She took it. No one named what had just happened. Outside, a vehicle passed along the road beyond the poplars. Neither of them moved towards the window. They

listened to its speed, its direction and the point at which the engine faded. Then Zoe opened her new notebook. On the first page, she wrote:

Do not look at the threat. Look at what changes around it.

Below that, after a moment, she added:

Trust is also a pattern.